

1346-51

THE BLACK DEATH

The pandemic known as the Black Death started in 1346 when an outbreak of bubonic plague struck the army of a Mongol prince laying siege to Kaffa, a Genoese trading settlement in Crimea. The Mongols lifted their siege, but after they withdrew the virus remained. Carried on the ships of Genoese traders, the plague swiftly advanced around the Mediterranean, from Syria and Egypt to Italy and southern France.

Europe's burgeoning and crowded cities were particularly vulnerable to the disease. Spread both by fleas on black rats and in the air from person to person, the plague reached England by 1348 and the Baltic by 1350. Fatality rates were

terrifyingly high, with possibly 80 per cent of those infected dying. Entire villages were wiped out and the worst-hit regions may have lost three-quarters of their people. Overall some 25 million may have died in Europe by the time the plague subsided in 1351 – about one in three of the continent's total population.

The plague spread widely across Eurasia, claiming millions of victims in China in 1353. Recurrences in Europe in the 1360s and 1370s particularly struck areas spared in the first pandemic. By 1400, England's population is reckoned to have fallen to half its pre-plague level and the overall population of Europe did not fully recover until the end of the 15th century.



KEY MOMENTS

1300s Silk Road

Endemic in central Asia, bubonic plague spread along the Silk Road trade routes (*left*) that linked China to Europe. The decline of trade in the 15th century reduced virus transmission.

1349-51 Massacres of Jews

Reacting to the mass death, Christians in Germany and other parts of Europe massacred thousands of Jewish people, accusing them of causing the epidemic by poisoning wells. In cities such as Strasbourg, Cologne, Mainz, and Frankfurt whole Jewish communities were exterminated (*left*).

1358 The Jacquerie

The Black Death caused widespread social disruption, contributing to years of disorder in Europe. In France, the peasant revolt known as the Jacquerie (*left*) arose in the wake of the pandemic, causing much death and destruction before it was bloodily suppressed.